Movers and Shakers

Social Movements in Africa

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Social movement theory: Past, present and prospects

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When and why do people protest? And who is likely to participate in public protests? Around 1900, influential sociologists regarded all street protest as deviant behaviour. The classic paradigms held that (relative) deprivation, shared grievances and generalized beliefs were determinants of protest. The early scholars of contentious politics depicted protest as the politics of the impatient, maintaining that protest had an irrational element to it. As dissatisfaction with these classic paradigms grew, new ones emerged: structural paradigms such as resource mobilization and political process. While resource mobilization theory focuses on organization as a resource, political process theory emphasizes the political element of protest. Simultaneous with the rise of the structural paradigms was the emergence of social-constructivistic paradigms that concentrate on how individuals and groups perceive and interpret socio-political conditions. They focus on the role of cognitive, affective and ideational roots of contention and are broadly organized around three concepts: framing, identity and emotions. This chapter discusses these concepts as well as the social-psychology approach to social movements. The socio-political context of contentious politics is changing due to processes such as globalization and liberalization, and it is argued that these changes influence the rise and fall of social movements and their collective actions. Most social movement scholars assume that mutual integration of the structural and constructivistic paradigms can yield satisfactory explanations.

Social movements and collective action

The reason why people protest has occupied social scientists for a long time. The French psychologist Le Bon, a founding father of collective action studies, regarded all street protest as a form of deviant behaviour and developed his theory on crowds during a period of great social unrest in France in the 1890s. He believed that the destruction of religious, political and social beliefs in combination with the creation of new conditions of existence and thought as a result of the modern scientific and industrial discoveries of the time were the basis for a process of transformation of mankind's thought. Ideas from the past, although half shattered, were still very powerful he believed, while the ideas that were to replace them were in a process of formation. The consequence, in his analysis, was a period of transition and anarchy. Le Bon's ideas were reflected in classic breakdown theories that regarded participation in collective action as an unconventional, irrational type of behaviour.[1] The classic paradigm held that (relative) deprivation, shared grievances and generalized beliefs were determinants of participation. In fact, early students of the subject depicted contentious politics as the politics of the impatient and maintained that protest had an irrational element to it.[2]

Times changed and so did both contentious politics and theoretical approaches to contentious politics. The late 1960s saw a huge growth in social movement activity: the student movement, the civil-rights movement, the peace movement, the women's movement and the environmental movement all flourished. Interpretations of major forms of collective action changed from being viewed as spontaneous 'irrational' outbursts to movement activities with concrete goals, articulated general values and interests, and rational calculations of strategies. Breakdown theories clearly fell short as explanations of this proliferation of social movement activity, all the more so because it seemed to be preceded by *growing* rather than *declining* welfare. This, combined with changing forms of collective action, required new theoretical approaches, and several developed in the 1970s.

These new theoretical approaches can be categorized as structural and social constructivistic paradigms. Resource mobilization and political process are examples of structural approaches. While resource mobilization places an emphasis on organizational aspects and resources, the political process approach emphasizes the political aspects of collective action. The social constructivistic perspective, on the other hand, concentrates on how individuals and groups perceive and interpret these conditions and focuses on the role of the cognitive,

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1 B. Klandermans, *The Social Psychology of Protest* (Blackwell Publishers, Oxford 1997).

2 N.J. Smelser, *Theory of Collective Behavior* (The Free Press, London, 1962).

affective and ideational roots of contention. It is broadly organized around three concepts: framing, identity and emotions (culture is also referred to but is not elaborated on in this chapter). These terms are also key concepts in social-psychology approaches to protest. Social psychologists maintain that people live in a perceived world and respond to the world as they observe and interpret it. To understand why people protest, it is necessary to know how they see and interpret their world, and social psychology focuses on subjective variables. Social-psychology approaches are, therefore, prototypical to social constructivistic approaches.

Obviously, the past and the present of social movement theory reveal different paradigms stressing various aspects of social movements and the actions they stage. They provide different answers to questions about why people protest, who protests and the forms of protest that protesters are involved in. Table 1 provides an overview of the answers provided to these questions by the different approaches to social movements.

Since the 1990s the context of contentious politics has changed significantly. Inseparably intertwined processes such as globalization, the development of the network society and the information society have given the world a new look. Networks are becoming the prime mode of organization, with formal networks embodied by organizations giving way to less formal networks rooted in the personal life world of individuals and to more diffuse group belongings.[3] Moreover, the rise of new communication technologies (the Internet, email, cell phones) is intensifying change and its pace.

Fundamental changes in society can affect contentious politics. After all, the spread of information and networks are essential elements of mobilization and one assumes that such fundamental changes are having a profound impact on the dynamics of contention. Indeed, scholars of social movements argue that recent social and cultural changes have lead to a 'normalization of protest'[4] and have created a social movement society.[5] This has posed new challenges to social movement theory. Are dynamics of contentious politics? In the final section of this chapter we will elaborate on what we see as the prospects of social movement theory and relate them to developments on the African continent. This is a precarious undertaking, especially considering the rapid pace of change.

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[3] J.W. Duyvendak & M. Hurenkamp (eds), *Kiezen voor de Kudde. Lichte gemeenschappen en de nieuwe meerderheid* (Van Gennep, Amsterdam, 2004).

[4] P. Norris, S. Walgrave & P. van Aelst, 'Who demonstrates? Anti-state rebels, conventional participants, or everyone?', *Comparative Politics*, 37, 2 (2005), pp. 189-205.

[5] D. Meyer & S. Tarrow (eds), *Towards a Movement Society? Contentious politics for a new century* (Rowman and Littlefield, Boulder, CO, 1998).

Table 1 Theories on participation and the emergence of social movements

	Classical approaches	**Contemporary approaches**		
	Mass society collective behaviour	***Resource mobilization***	***Political process approach***	***Social constructivistic approaches***
Why people protest	Grievances, discontent, anomie, class conflict	Resources, opportunities, social networks efficacy	Political opportunities (cognitive liberation)	Social construction of reality: - (meaning) construction - identity - emotions - motivation
Who protests	Alienated, frustrated, disintegrated, manipulated, marginalized people	Well-organized, professional, resourceful social networks; embeddedness	Coalitions between challengers / political elites; embeddedness	Countercultural groups, identity groups; embeddedness
Forms of protest	Spontaneous, irrational, expressive, violent (panics, fashions, mobs, crime)	Rational, planned, instrumental (institutional politics, lobbying, interest groups)	Rational, instrumental, polity-oriented (elite contention lobbying, indigenous minorities disruption i.e. sit-ins, strikes)	Ideological, expressive, identity-oriented (cultural and religious organizations, self-help groups, alternative lifestyles)

First however, we discuss the past and the present of social movement theory and sketch our subject of interest, namely social movements and collective action. There are numerous definitions of what a 'social movement' is. In this chapter a few definitions will be given, all departing from different theoretical angles and emphasizing different aspects of the phenomenon. A working definition of what we see as social movements and (their) collective actions is as follows: social movements are interlocking networks of groups, social networks

and individuals, and the connection between them is a shared collective identity that tries to prevent or promote societal change by non-institutionalized tactics.[6]

Breakdown and marginalization: The past

Classical approaches, for example collective behaviour theory, mass society theory and relative deprivation, rely on the same general causal sequence moving from 'some form of structural strain (be it industrialization, urbanization, unemployment) [that] produces subjective tension and therefore the psychological disposition to engage in extreme behaviours such as panics, mobs etc. to escape from these tensions'.[7] The various versions of classical approaches agree on this basic sequence and differ only in their conceptualization. To appreciate the similarities underlying these various formulations, let us briefly review a number of them.

Le Bon, as mentioned earlier, can be seen as the founding father of collective action studies and his ideas are reflected in several subsequent theories. He did not conceive of contentious politics in a very positive manner, perceiving crowds as primitive and irrational. He believed that individual members of a crowd become submerged in the masses, assuming a sense of anonymity and losing their sense of responsibility. Today, however, it is felt that Le Bon exaggerated the violent and irrational character of crowds.

Smelser[8] and Blumer[9] are viewed as breakdown theorists. Both held that political protest had its inception in tension and societal transition as a result of industrialization, urbanization and unemployment, and that it derived its motivational power from dissatisfaction with current forms of life. For Blumer, the motivating forces for collective action were, in addition to dissatisfaction and subsequent agitation, 'wishes' and 'hope' for a new scheme or system of living. In this way he dissociated himself from the notion that contentious politics were irrational acts rooted solely in agitation and frustration. Implicitly, in emotional terms, he depicted a rational, efficacious side to contentious politics. This perceived probability of making a difference was later described as 'cognitive liberation'.[10]

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6 D. della Porta & M. Diani (eds), *Social Movements: An introduction* (Basil Blackwell, Oxford, 1999).

7 D. McAdam, *Political Process and the Development of Black Insurgency, 1930-1970* (University of Chicago Press, Chicago, 1982), p. 7.

8 Smelser, *Theory of Collective Behavior*.

9 H.G. Blumer, 'Collective behavior', in A. McClung Lee (ed.), *Principles of Sociology* (Barnes and Noble Books, New York, 1969).

10 McAdam, *Political Process and the Development of Black Insurgency*.

Kornhauser[11] popularized the notion that people were vulnerable to the appeals of dictatorship because of a lack of restraining social networks. He argued that Nazism developed in Germany because Hitler was able to appeal directly to the people due to their alienation and anomie. This conforms to Putnam's more recent discussions of the alleged decline of social capital[12] but stands in contrast to social movement studies that consistently show that it is people who are firmly embedded, rather than those who are alienated, who are politically active.[13] Indeed, 'very little participation [is found] in either ordinary political activity or revolutionary outbursts by misfits, outcasts, nomads, the truly marginal, the desperate poor'.[14]

Gurr[15] argued that when changing social conditions cause people to experience 'relative deprivation', the likelihood of protest and rebellion significantly increases. Feelings of relative deprivation result from comparisons of one's situation with some standard be it in one's own past or in someone else's situation, or some cognitive standard.[16] If one concludes that one is not receiving the rewards or recognition one deserves, the feelings that accompany this assessment are referred to as relative deprivation. If people assess their personal situation, this is egoistic or individual deprivation; if they assess the situation of their group, it is called fraternalistic or group deprivation. It was assumed that fraternalistic relative deprivation was especially relevant in the context of movement participation.[17]

In conclusion, classical approaches tend to describe contentious politics as spontaneous, irrational, expressive and often violent outbursts of collective action in reaction to felt grievances, discontent and anomie. Protesters, according to classical approaches, are stressed, alienated, frustrated, deprived, disintegrated and marginalized individuals affected by economic crises, an unfair distribution of welfare, social rights, and normative breakdown.

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11 W. Kornhauser, *The Politics of Mass Society* (The Free Press, London, 1995).

12 R. Putnam, *Making Democracy Work: Civic traditions in modern Italy* (Princeton University Press, Princeton, NJ, 1993).

13 McAdam, *Political Process and the Development of Black Insurgency*; B. Klandermans, J. van der Toorn & J. van Stekelenburg, 'Embeddedness and grievances: Collective action participation among immigrants', *American Sociological Review*, 73 (2008), pp. 992-1012.

14 C. Tilly, *The Contentious French* (The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, Cambridge, MA, 1986).

15 T. Gurr, *Why Men Rebel* (Princeton University Press, Princeton, NJ, 1970).

16 W.G. Runciman, *Relative Deprivation and Social Justice* (Routledge, London, 1966).

17 *Ibid*.

Resources, opportunities and meaning: The present

With the growth in social movement activity on both sides of the Atlantic in the late 1960s, protest started to be perceived as positive and a way of improving politics. It was even seen as essential in a mature political system, rather than as threatening or undermining democracies.[18] Social movement scholars of the 1970s and 1980s, who often happened to be activists themselves, were not persuaded by theories that labelled them as alienated, frustrated and disintegrated and their protest behaviour as irrational. They felt that the psychological make-up attributed to movement participants by the classical approaches did not fit them and argued that, if anything, movement participants were integrated rather than isolated.[19] Clearly, the classical approaches failed to account for this outburst of social movement activity being seen as positive rational politics and preceded by a *growth* rather than a decline in welfare.

The changing perspectives on contentious politics and the growth of social movement activity in prosperous times made researchers in the US and Europe question where, if not from deprivation, social movement activity comes from. The answer was sought in different directions. In the US, structural approaches shifted attention from deprivation to the availability of resources, political opportunities and mobilizing structures to explain the rise of social movements, while in Europe, the social constructivistic 'New Social Movement' (NSM) approach focused attention on the growth of new protest potential, with grievances and aspirations resulting from the developing post-industrial society.[20] While the structural approaches in the US tend to pay a great deal of attention to the *how* of collective action, the social constructivistic approaches in Europe attempt to explain *why* individuals are inclined to such actions.[21] We will explore these approaches in turn.

Structural approaches

Structural approaches investigate how characteristics of social and political context determine the opportunities or constraints for protest. These approaches reject grievances and ideology as the explanation for the rise and decline of movements. Structural approaches have always taken as their point of departure the fact that grievances are ubiquitous and that the key question in movement participation research is not so much why people are aggrieved, as why aggrieved people participate. Two main paradigms emphasize, firstly, the distri-

[18] *Ibid*.
[19] McAdam, *Political Process and the Development of Black Insurgency*.
[20] B. Klandermans, H. Kriesi & S. Tarrow (eds), *From Structure to Action: Comparing social movement research across cultures,* Vol. 1 (JAI Press, Greenwich, CT, 1988).
[21] *Ibid*.

bution of resources and the organizational characteristics of social movements ('resource mobilization') and, secondly, contextual factors such as the political and institutional environment ('political process').

Resource mobilization theorists wanted to move away from strong assumptions about the centrality of deprivation and grievances to a view that sees grievances as being a component – sometimes a secondary one – in the generation of social movements.[22] Assigning grievances a subordinate position in theories explaining the rise and fall of social movements leads directly to an emphasis on mobilization processes or the dynamics and tactics of social movement growth, decline and change.

> The resource mobilization approach examines the variety of resources that must be mobilized, the linkages of social movements to other groups, the dependence of movements upon external support for success, and the tactics used by authorities to control or incorporate movements.[23]

Resources can mean anything from material resources – jobs, income, savings and the right to specific goods and services – to non-tangible resources, such as authority, leadership, moral commitment, trust, friendship, skills and habits of industry. The reasoning goes that group conflict in its dynamic aspects can be conceptualized from the point of view of the mobilization of resources. Mobilization refers to the processes by which a discontented group assembles and invests resources for the pursuit of group goals. Conflict and change can be analyzed from the point of view of how resources are managed and allocated and the manner in which these resources can be redirected in the pursuit of group goals.

Resource mobilization scholars view social movements as a set of opinions and beliefs in a population that represents preferences for promoting or preventing social change.[24] To predict the likelihood of preferences being translated into protest, the mobilization perspective focuses on pre-existing organization and the integration of those parts of a population that share the preferences. Social movements whose related populations are highly organized internally are more likely than others to spawn organized forms of protest. Resource mobilization theorists focus explicitly on the organizational component of activity. They argue that resources (money, labour, legitimacy, etc.) must be mobilized for action to be possible. The degree of activity directed towards the accomplishment of goals is perceived by resource mobilization theorists as a function of the resources controlled by an organization. In summary, people

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[22] J.D. McCarthy & M.N. Zald, 'Resource mobilization and social movements: A partial theory', *American Journal of Sociology,* 82, 6 (1977), pp. 1212-1241.

[23] *Ibid*., p. 1212.

[24] *Ibid*.

protest from a resource mobilization perspective because they are able to mobilize resources and feel politically successful. Prototypical protesters are rational, well-organized, professional and resourceful people who undertake well-planned collective action with the goal of solving social problems.

Resource mobilization theory has not escaped criticism. It borrows its concept from the vocabulary of economics (the flow of resources, costs and benefits, supply and demand, organization, movement entrepreneurs, movement industries) and is particularly suited to the depiction of social movements such as rational entities weighing up the costs and benefits of their action.[25] However, expressions such as 'costs and benefits' may make activists and scholars of social movements feel uncomfortable, as they convey notions of cold calculation being applied to social action which instead is often inspired by ideals and passion. But this is exactly the notion that resource mobilization theorists want to convey, namely that the ebb and flow of social movement activity results from the ability to mobilize resources and the perceived chances of success rather than from rising or declining grievance levels. In addition, it has been argued that resource mobilization theorists fail to acknowledge the strength of indigenous resources. For instance, McAdam shows that the growth of the black insurgency movement in America in the 1960s was related to 'injected' resources from elites but that indigenous resources such as informal networks providing solidarity, trust and leadership were important as well.[26] Finally, 'resource mobilization theorists are to be faulted for their failure to acknowledge the power inherent in disruptive tactics'.[27] Piven and Cloward have argued that opportunities for protest occur when broad social changes and the restructuring of institutional life take place. Under such circumstances, the poor will take the opportunity to use the only power resource they have, namely protest. However, these 'extraordinary occurrences' that are 'required to transform the poor from apathy to hope, from quiescence to indignation'[28] are limited in number. In normal circumstances, the struggle to survive takes up all the time and energy poor people have, and only when daily life severely breaks down does protest emerge.

While resource mobilization theorists explain the rise and fall of social movements by features internal to the movements themselves, such as the availability of resources and organizational aspects, political process theorists focus on external features, like changes or differences in the political and institutional environment of social movements. They argue that political environments vary

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25 *Ibid*.

26 McAdam, *Political Process and the Development of Black Insurgency*.

27 *Ibid*., p. 30.

28 F.F. Piven & R.A. Cloward, *Poor Peoples' Movements: Why they succeed, how they fail* (Random House, New York, 1977), p. 14.

over time and between areas. The paradigm proposes changes in or differences between political structures as the main explanation for the rise and fall of social movements and that differences from one country or era to another stem from the process by which a national political system shapes, checks and absorbs the challenges confronting it.[29]

Three ideas are central to the political process approach: first, a social movement is a political rather than a psychological phenomenon; second, a social movement represents a continuous *process* from its creation to its decline rather than a discrete series of developmental stages; and third, different forms of action ('repertoires of contentions') are associated with different spatial and temporal locations.[30] For Tilly, one of the leading theorists of the political process approach, action repertoires are specific actions such as riots, demonstrations, strikes, sit-ins, petitioning or lobbying that are carried out by collective actors over a specific period of time. Tarrow expands this concept and suggests that 'actions are not only what people do when they are engaged in conflict with others, it is what they know how to do and what others expect them to do'.[31] The form of action chosen by social movements depends on factors including the structure of the political system (e.g. democratic institutions, the existence and structure of political parties, and possibilities for direct participation), the level of repression, and cultural traditions. The actions of social actors are, therefore, not purely random. Instead, action repertoires are shaped by structural variables and the cultural context in which they originate.

By studying the changing action repertoires in France over the last four centuries, Tilly[32] demonstrated that social movements draw on action repertoires that develop over long periods and change in conformity in an evolving context. If a prevailing repertoire of contention changes significantly at some point, the change is a symptom of a substantial alteration in the structure of power. An expansion of the state in nineteenth-century France, including a nationalization of politics, was, for instance, accompanied by a major change in the repertoire of collective action. The more spontaneous tax rebellions and bread riots aimed at the local authorities more or less disappeared and were replaced by more coherent forms of contention. The centralization of the state played an essential part in the creation of modern social movements with a

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[29] C. Tilly, 'Social movements and national politics', in: C. Bright & S. Hardine (eds), *Statemaking and Social Movements: Essays in history and theory* (University of Michigan Press, Ann Arbor, MI, 1984).

[30] Tilly, *The Contentious French*.

[31] S. Tarrow, *Power in Movement: Collective action, social movements and politics* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1994), p. 31.

[32] Tilly, *The Contentious French*.

repertoire that is still present today: the strike, the demonstration, and the protest meeting.

Tarrow[33] studied the cycle of protest that swept across Italy from the late 1960s through the early 1970s and showed how protest spread from students' and workers' movements to virtually every sector of Italian society and gave rise to extra-parliamentary groups, violence and, finally, a return to traditional political patterns. In other words, by utilizing the political opportunities offered by the system, social movements create an ideologically and socially favourable environment for new social groups to mobilize.

Political structures have also explained differences in protest activity *between* countries.[34] For instance, the protest repertoire of social movements in Switzerland that were struggling within a direct democracy appeared to be more moderate than the radical repertoire employed by French social movements fighting their cause in a closed democracy.[35] To strengthen the case for the argument that direct democratic procedures have a moderating effect on the action repertoires of social movements, Kriesi and Wisler[36] showed that within one country, the Swiss federal state, differences between Swiss cantons regarding direct democratic procedures had an impact on the action repertoires employed within these cantons. The German-speaking cantons were more open than the Latin ones and, not surprisingly, social movements based in the German cantons employed a less radical action repertoire than their Latin counterparts.

McAdam is a political process theorist who, while emphasizing structural aspects of the environment, also focuses on subjectivity. He explained the rise and fall of the civil-rights movement in the United States between 1930 and 1970 with reference to political opportunities, political efficacy and institutions like black churches and black colleges.[37] While classical theorists saw a direct link between social instability and political insurgency, McAdam saw only an indirect relationship, as illustrated in Figure 1.

McAdam argues that two necessary conditions need to be in place to turn social instability into political insurgency: (i) available resources and open

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[33] S. Tarrow, *Democracy and Disorder: Protest and politics in Italy 1965-1975* (Clarendon Press, Oxford, 1989).

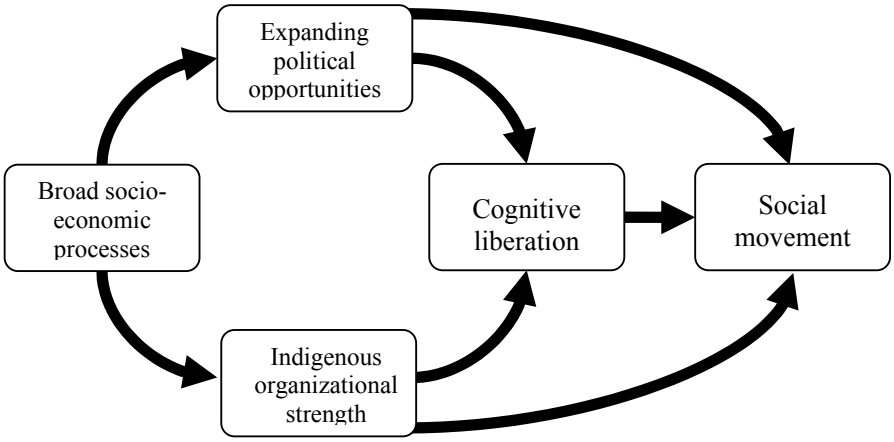
[34] P. Eisinger, 'The conditions of protest behavior in American cities', *American Political Science Review*, 67 (1973), pp. 11-15.

[35] H. Kriesi, R. Koopmans, J.W. Duyvendak & M. Giugni, *New Social Movements in Western Europe* (University of Minnesota Press, Minneapolis, MN, 1995).

[36] H. Kriesi & D. Wisler, 'Direct democracy and social movements in Switzerland', *European Journal of Political Research*, 30 (1996), pp. 19-40.

[37] McAdam, *Political Process and the Development of Black Insurgency*, p. 7.

Figure 1 McAdam's 1982 political process model



political opportunities, and (ii) cognitive liberation. Although the political process model builds upon the resource mobilization approach, in contrast to this approach, it also takes the indigenous organizational capabilities of aggrieved populations into account. The second condition, that of cognitive liberation, proposes that the subjectivity of actors makes resources usable and collective action viable, and helps actors and groups to frame their situation as unjust and liable to change.[38] Political opportunities and organization alone do not produce social movements. Mediating between political opportunities and organizational strength are people and their hopes and fears. In general, the political process approach argues that the ebb and flow of movement activity is related to the opening up and closure of political opportunities. Protesters are rational, instrumental, polity-oriented people who seize opportunities by lobbying and forming coalitions with political elites.

Several studies make a convincing case for the political process approach but some fail to explain political protest, and others show that the approach is more effective in one context than another. The lack of theory concerning the specific mechanisms that link political process to movement activity is identified as the fundamental problem in explaining these divergent results.[39] Moreover, incen-

[38] Piven & Cloward, *Poor Peoples' Movements*.

[39] R. Koopmans, 'The missing link between structure and agency. Outline of an evolutionary approach to social movements', *Mobilization*, 10 (2005), pp. 19-36.

tives and expectations necessarily involve interpretation, just like opportunities and constraints.[40] Indeed, if there were a perfect correlation between objective and subjective environments, there would be no need to distinguish between the two, whereas research suggests that this is often not the case.[41]

Social constructivistic approaches

The development of social movement activity in the prosperous times of the second half of the twentieth century shows differences between the US and Europe. While there was an emphasis in the US on structural aspects such as resources and political opportunities, answers were formulated in Europe in terms of new constituencies with new needs, values and aspirations arising from developing post-industrial societies, producing what were dubbed New Social Movements. This 'NSM approach' argued that processes of modernization created two groups of constituencies. The first were groups that had lagged behind due to marginalization processes related to industrial modernization (youth, women and the elderly were especially seen as groups threatened by the automation of productive work). The second were groups with a specific vulnerability resulting from modernization processes.[42] In particular, the post-war generation, whose material needs were satisfied, developed post-material values from which emerged such new needs and aspirations as self-actualization and participation.[43] This group came into conflict with a political and social system that was chiefly materialistic. The NSM approach was social constructivistic in emphasizing social changes in identity, lifestyle and culture. NSM scholars utilized identity as their core concept, with Melucci arguably being the most explicit.[44] He thought collective identity 'bridge[s] the gap between behavior and meaning, between "objective" conditions and "subjective" motives and orientation, between "structure" and "agency"'.[45]

However, social constructivistic approaches were not an exclusively European matter and the hegemony of structural approaches in the US began to be

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40 J. Goodwin & J.M. Jasper, 'Caught in a winding, snarling vine: The structural bias of political process theory', *Sociological Forum,* 14, 1 (1999), pp. 27-54.

41 B. Boyd, G.G. Dess & A. Rasheed, 'Divergence between archival and perceptual measures of the environment: causes and consequences,' *Academy of Management Review,* 18, 2 (1993), pp. 204-226.

42 Klandermans, Kriesi & Tarrow, *From Structure to Action*.

43 R. Inglehart, *The Silent Revolution: Changing values and political styles among Western publics* (Princeton University Press, Princeton, NJ, 1977).

44 A. Melucci, *Nomads of the Present: Social movement and identity needs in contemporary society* (Temple University Press, Philadelphia, PA, 1989).

45 A. Melucci, *Challenging Code* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1996), p. 69.

challenged in the mid 1980s.[46] The social constructivistic perspective concentrates on questions of how individuals and groups perceive and interpret material and socio-political conditions. Social constructivists argue that if we want to understand why people protest, we need to know how they perceive and interpret their social-political context. A number of European and US social movement scholars with social-psychology backgrounds called for attention to be paid to meaning and its construction and identity. They referred to explanations founded in emotion, such as interpretation, symbolization and meaning, and to social-psychology expansions of structural approaches such as resource mobilization.[47] They argued that structural explanations are limited because individuals who are in the same structural position do not display identical behaviour. A shared position can never provide sufficient explanation of individual behaviour.[48] Even if people display identical behaviour, their motivational background and their accompanying emotions may still be different.[49]

This social constructivistic approach draws on past views but is not a return to the classical approaches of the 1950s. While both classical and social constructivistic approaches recognize that emotions and cognition are important to collective action, the classical approaches see them as pathological, whereas social constructivistic approaches perceive them as the normal, ubiquitous aspects of social and political life. Social constructivistic approaches try to understand why people who are seemingly in the same situation respond so differently. They question why some people feel ashamed of their situation, while others take pride in it; why some are aggrieved, while others are not; why some define their situation as unjust, while others do not; why some feel powerless, while others feel empowered; and why some are angry, while others are afraid. These are the issues that social constructivistic approaches to social movements seek to answer. We now turn to meaning (or construction), identity, and emotional and motivational explanations as examples of contemporary social constructivistic approaches.

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[46] R. Benford, 'An insider's critique of the social movement framing perspective', *Sociological Inquiry*, 67*,* 4 (1997), pp. 409-430.

[47] B. Klandermans, 'Mobilization and participation: Social-psychological expansions of resource mobilization theory', *American Sociological Review*, 49, 5 (1984), pp. 583-600.

[48] D. Snow & P. Oliver, 'Social movements and collective behavior: Social psychological considerations and dimensions', in: K.S. Cook, G.A. Fine & J.S. House (eds), *Sociological Perspectives on Social Psychology* (Allyn and Bacon, Boston, MA, 1995).

[49] J. van Stekelenburg & B. Klandermans, 'Individuals in movements: A social psychology of contention', in: B. Klandermans & C.M. Roggeband (eds), *The Handbook of Social Movements Across Disciplines* (Springer, New York, 2007).

The first involves the meaning that people attach to their social environment. This is the direct or indirect subject of investigation by students of protest. Perceptions are not fixed but are susceptible to interpretation and thus play a role in the construction of meaning.[50] And participation in collective action thus depends not only on perceptions of structural strain, availability and the deployment of material resources, the opening up or closing of political opportunities or a cost-benefit calculation more generally but also on the way these variables are constructed and framed and the degree to which they resonate with targets of mobilization.[51]

Social movements play a significant role in the diffusion of ideas and values to the extent that some scholars see the construction of meaning as a movement's primary function.[52] Through processes such as consensus mobilization[53] or framing,[54] activists seek to disseminate their definition of a situation to the public at large. Participating because of common interests or ideologies requires a shared interpretation of who should act, and why and how. Movements affect such interpretations by the information they disseminate, a process known as 'framing'. Social movements do their utmost to communicate how they interpret a social, political or economic change (its diagnosis) and what should be done (the prognosis) as a reaction to perceived losses or unfulfilled aspirations.[55] The more individual orientations, values and beliefs become congruent with activities, goals and ideologies of social movement organizations, the greater the level of sharedness. Gerhards and Rucht's study[56] of flyers produced by the various groups and organizations involved in protests against the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the World Bank in Berlin is an excellent example in this respect. The researchers showed how links were constructed between the ideological framework of the organizers of the demonstration and those of the participating organizations to create a shared definition of the situation.

With regard to social identity, the clearest definition that has been located in the social-psychology literature is presented by Tajfel and Turner. According to

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50 W.A. Gamson, *Talking Politics* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1992).

51 D.A. Snow, E.B. Rochford, S.K. Worden & R.D. Benford, 'Frame alignment processes, micromobilization, and movement participation', *American Sociological Review*, 51 (1986), pp. 464-481.

52 R. Eyerman & A. Jamison, *Social Movements: A cognitive approach* (Polity Press, Cambridge, 1991).

53 Klandermans, Kriesi & Tarrow, *From Structure to Action*.

54 Snow *et al*., 'Frame alignment processes'.

55 *Ibid*.

56 J. Gerhards & D. Rucht, 'Mesomobilization: Organizing and framing in two protest campaigns in West Germany', *American Journal of Sociology*, 98, (1992), pp. 555–596.

them, identity is 'that *part* of an individual's self-concept which derives from his knowledge of his membership of a social group (or groups) together with the value and emotional significance attached to that membership'.[57] Hence a social identity makes people think, feel and act as members of that specific group. But people have many social identities. Why do some social identities become central to mobilization while others do not? Probably the most powerful factor that brings group membership to mind is conflict or rivalry between groups, and in times of inter-group conflict, people are inclined to take to the streets on behalf of their group.

Collective action is a group rather than an individual phenomenon but in the end it is individuals who decide whether or not to participate. This raises the question of what connects the individual to the collective. Identification with the group involved seems to be the answer. The influence of identification processes on protest participation refers to the circumstances in which people identify with the others involved. People participate not so much because of the outcome associated with participation but because they identify with the other participants. Group identification changes the focus from what 'I' want to what 'we' want. Collective action participation is seen as a way to show who 'we' are and what 'we' stand for, and people experience commitment and solidarity with other members of the group. In addition, group members have the idea that 'we' have much in common (by way of shared grievances, aims, values or goals). Group identification seems to be a powerful reason for participating in protest.[58]

Little is known about the influence of emotions on protest behaviour. Yet it is acknowledged that emotions permeate all the stages in social movement participation: recruitment, staying in and dropping out. Emotions function as accelerators or amplifiers,[59] making things move more quickly or sound louder. In the world of protest, 'accelerating' means that one's motives for joining, staying in or leaving a social movement translate into action more quickly due to emotions, while 'amplifying' means that these motives become stronger. Few researchers have focused on the complex emotional processes that channel fear and anger into moral indignation and political activity. Those of us who have been part of protest events or have watched reports on protest events in the media may find this hard to believe. However partly as a reaction to the classi-

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[57] H. Tajfel & J.C. Turner, 'An integrative theory of intergroup conflict', in S. Worchel and W.G. Austin (eds), *The Social Psychology of Intergroup Relations* (Brooks/ Cole, Monterey, CA, 1979), p. 63.

[58] For overviews, see S. Stryker, T.J. Owens & R.W. White (eds), *Self, Identity, and Social Movements* (Minnesota Press, Minneapolis, MN, 2000) and N. Ellemers, R. Spears & B. Doosje (eds), *Social Identity: Context, commitment, content* (Blackwell Publishers, Oxford, 1999).

[59] Van Stekelenburg & Klandermans, 'Individuals in movements'.

cal approaches that stressed the irrational character of movement participation and partly because they are complicated phenomena, emotions have not featured prominently in the social movement literature. Even 'affective' phenomena such as moral shocks[60] or suddenly imposed grievances[61] have been primarily approached from a cognitive point of view. But all demands for change begin with discontent. Emotions warn people of threats and challenges and propel behaviour. Moreover, affective measures, such as affective commitment[62] and injustice,[63] have the biggest impact on behaviour. Thus if one wants to understand engagement in collective action, one must understand the workings of emotions.

Goodwin, Jasper and Polletta argue that emotions are socially constructed but that 'some emotions are more [socially] constructed than others, involving more cognitive processes'. [64] In their view, emotions that are politically relevant are at the social construction end of the scale. For these emotions, cultural and historical factors play an important role in the interpretation (i.e. perception) of the state of affairs by which they are generated. Obviously, emotions can be manipulated. Activists work hard to create moral outrage and anger and to provide a target against which these can be vented. They have to weave a moral, cognitive and emotional blanket of attitudes. Framing theory has provided a way to link ideas and the social construction of ideas with organizational and political process factors. These studies, however, deal almost entirely with the cognitive components of frames and neglect any emotional components. Powerful frames might, however, be related to the values and emotions that they contain and it might be argued that frames not only resonate cognitively but also emotionally.

These issues are all related to questions of motivation. Demands for change are rooted in a notion of belonging (identity) and experienced grievances (constructed meaning) in combination with emotions related to a specific grievance. Although, typically, many members of disadvantaged groups are dissatisfied with their collective situation and strongly sympathize with the goals of collective actions, often only a small proportion actually participate in protest to

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60 J.M. Jasper, *The Art of Moral Protest* (University of Chicago Press, Chicago, IL, 1997).

61 E.J. Walsh, 'Resource mobilization and citizen protest in communities around Three Mile Island', *Social Problems*, 29, 1 (1981), pp. 1-21.

62 Ellemers *et al*., *Social Identity*.

63 T.R. Tyler & H.J. Smith, 'Social justice and social movements', in D.T. Gilbert & S.T. Fiske (eds), *Handbook of Social Psychology*, 4th ed. (McGraw-Hill, Oxford, 1998).

64 J. Goodwin, J.M. Jasper & F. Polletta, *Passionate Politics: Emotions and social movements* (The University of Chicago Press, Chicago, IL, 2001), p. 13.

achieve these goals.[65] In collective action research therefore, the motives underlying participation have become a key issue.[66]

Over the last two decades, social psychologists have investigated the motives behind participation and demonstrated that instrumental reasoning, identification, emotions and ideological factors form a motivational constellation in response to the question about why people participate in contentious politics.[67] Interestingly though, this motivational constellation seems to be context dependent: Van Stekelenburg, Klandermans and van Dijk ,[68] for instance, showed that, in demonstrations organized by a labour movement, people tend to be instrumentally motivated whereas demonstrators against neoliberalism are more ideologically motivated. In more general terms, people are inclined to take the instrumental path if a conflict is framed in terms of material interests and the ideological path if it is framed in terms of conflicting principles.

In conclusion, social constructivistic approaches argue that protesters live in a perceived reality and that threats and opportunities are socially constructed and/or framed by social movements and other social and political actors. Group identification plays a key role in what protesters think, feel and do and protesting is as rational or irrational as all social behaviour. People participate therefore not only in collective action for instrumental reasons but also because they identify with others involved or because they want to express their anger and indignation at a target if they believe that their values have been violated. Social constructivistic approaches investigate how perceptions, emotions and identities shape a person's motivation to take part in contentious politics. There appears to be a great deal of merit in utilizing social constructivistic approaches alongside structural approaches when studying contentious politics. However, social constructivistic approaches are characterized by their variety. They have four key themes – the construction of meaning, identity, emotions and motivation – but a common framework to allow the integration of these variables is clearly missing. Social constructivistic studies tend to consist of single case-studies that inevitably have little to say about contextual variation. However, one needs to understand the characteristics of the socio-political and mobilizing context to make sense of the findings in a specific country or period of time. This requires comparative studies rather than single case-studies.

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65 G. Marwell & P. Oliver, *The Critical Mass in Collective Action: A micro-social theory* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1993); Klandermans, *The Social Psychology of Protest*.

66 *Ibid*.

67 *Ibid*.

68 J. van Stekelenburg, B. Klandermans & W.W. van Dijk, 'Context matters: Explaining why and how mobilizing context influences motivational dynamics', *Journal of Social Issues* (forthcoming, 2009).

The social constructivistic approach thus runs the risk of fragmentation and decontextualization. In an attempt to bridge the gap between the objective existence of the opportunities and resources in the environment, as opposed to the protesters' subjective perception, social constructivistic approaches clearly need a common framework that integrates key themes and takes the socio-political context into account.

Contextualized contestation: The prospects

In the rapidly globalizing world of the network society and the information society,[69] streams of migration are creating diasporas in which flows of ideas and resources are influencing contentious politics in both their homelands and in their host countries. At the same time, globalization has resulted in more transnational and supranational political institutions such as the European Union, the United Nations and the IMF that are having an ever-increasing impact on people's daily lives. Some scholars believe they can detect the emergence of a new social fabric, which they have baptized the 'network society',[70] arguing that networks have become the prime mode of organization and structure of society. Formal organizations have turned into networks of networks, which in turn are intersected with informal networks rooted in personal life worlds and more diffuse interpersonal group settings. The logic of the network society pervades all spheres of social, economic and cultural life.[71] In addition, new communication technologies are giving rise to the information society,[72] as new technologies intensify societal change and pace. As Held puts it:

> … what is new about the modern global system is the chronic intensification of patterns of interconnectedness mediated by such phenomena as the modern communication industry and new information technology and the spread of globalization in and through new dimensions of interconnectedness.[73]

It should be noted that Held made his statement at a time when the real communication revolution was still to come.

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69 M. Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society* (Blackwell Publishers, Oxford, 1996); H. Rheingold, *Smart Mobs: The next social revolution* (Perseus, Cambridge, MA, 2002); B. Wellman, 'The network community', in B. Wellman (ed.), *Networks in the Global Village* (Westview, Boulder, CO, 1999), pp. 1-48; R.K. Garrett, 'Protest in an information society: A review of literature on social movements and new ICTs', *Information, Communication, and Society*, 9, 2 (2006), pp. 202-224.

70 Castells, *The Rise of the Network Society*.

71 *Ibid*.

72 Garrett, 'Protest in an information society'.

73 D. Held, 'Democracy, the nation-state and the global system', in David Held (ed.), *Political Theory Today* (Polity Press, Cambridge, 1991), p. 145.

Societies are changing fundamentally and this affects contentious politics. After all, information and networks are essential elements of mobilization and one could assume that such profound changes must be having an impact on the dynamics of contention. And as a result of these transformations, the field of contentious politics has changed significantly.[74] Protest as a political tactic has diffused across a range of constituencies and claims. Contributing to and resulting from such diffusion is an increased tolerance for protest so that engaging in political protest is no longer stigmatized. Moreover, protest in Western democracies has generally been an effective tool for politically disadvantaged groups both on the left and the right.[75] This conveys the message that the tactic is not only legitimate but also effective. Simply because more citizens have protested more frequently and on more diverse issues, more experienced protesters are available for subsequent protest calls.[76] The legitimacy of protest, its proven efficacy and the ample experience of protest among citizens will all influence the dynamics of contention.

Changing society, changing paradigms?

Perhaps more than in any other sector of comparative politics, the study of contention is sensitive to developments in the real world.[77] We therefore assume that, just as in the 1960s, contemporary changes in society will give rise to new approaches. Contentious politics is a multi-faceted phenomenon with socio-political, organizational and social-psychology roots. To investigate who rebels and on what issues requires inclusive models. Yet the connection between structures that canalize grievances into contentious politics is a thorny but relatively underexposed issue in the protest literature.

This observation is not new. In 1988 Klandermans, Kriesi and Tarrow suggested a research agenda with the emphasis on comparative research and the integration of structural, cultural and motivational factors.[78] Their book was the first tangible outcome of a prolonged exchange between representatives of the

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[74] D. della Porta & S. Tarrow (eds), *Transnational Protest and Global Activism* (Rowman and Littlefield, Lanham, MD, 2005).

[75] W.A. Gamson, *Strategy of Social Protest* (Wadsworth Publishing, Belmont, CA, 1990).

[76] V. Taylor, 'Mobilizing for change in a social movement society', *Contemporary Sociology*, 29, 1 (2000), pp. 219-230; Meyer & Tarrow, *Towards a Movement Society?*

[77] D. McAdam, S. Tarrow & C. Tilly, 'Comparative perspectives on contentious politics', in: M. Lichbach & A. Zuckerman (eds), *Ideas, Interests and Institutions: Advancing theory in comparative politics* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 2007).

[78] Klandermans, Kriesi & Tarrow, *From Structure to Action.*

American and European approaches and this resulted in an increasingly closely knit network of contacts across the Atlantic that was instrumental in organizing a series of conferences and edited volumes. In 1996 a book edited by McAdam, McCarthy and Zald[79] was released with a widely shared synthesis of three broad sets of factors to analyze the emergence and development of social movements: the structure of political opportunities and constraints confronting the movement; mobilizing structures; and framing processes. Two additional synthesizing efforts came in 1999 from Della Porta and Diani[80] and in 2004 from Snow, Soule and Kriesi,[81] all of whom drew together political opportunity, movement framing and the social network theory. So although social constructivistic approaches are usually framed as being opposed to structuralist accounts, the contemporary research agenda calls for an integration of structural, political and sociological theories of movements with social constructivistic approaches rooted in social psychology and cultural sociology. Yet research agendas focusing on comparative research and theoretical syntheses of structure and agency are as relevant today as they ever were. To be sure, theories of contentious politics are currently more sophisticated than previously but many questions remain unresolved, such as how the political and mobilizing context 'translates' into contentious politics. These questions require interdisciplinary and comparative studies. Such studies have not featured prominently in the social movement literature, perhaps because truly interdisciplinary and comparative studies are so complex. Therefore, the question as to how characteristics of socio-political structure might translate into action is as relevant now as it was in 1988 when Klandermans, Kriesi and Tarrow first drew attention to it.

An explanatory framework, which we developed in collaboration with Stefaan Walgrave, might be useful here because it highlights precisely the interaction between structure and action as its point of departure. It crosses interdisciplinary boundaries that connect the micro level of individual protesters with the meso level of social movements, and the macro level of national political systems and supranational processes. We started from the notion that the answer to questions such as who protests, why people protest (i.e. the issues) and the forms of contention (e.g. grassroots activity, civil war) lies in the interaction of supranational processes, political processes at the national level and the mobilizing context (see Figure 2).

What follows elaborates on contextual variation. Given that this is a chapter in a book on social movements in Africa, the framework will be discussed

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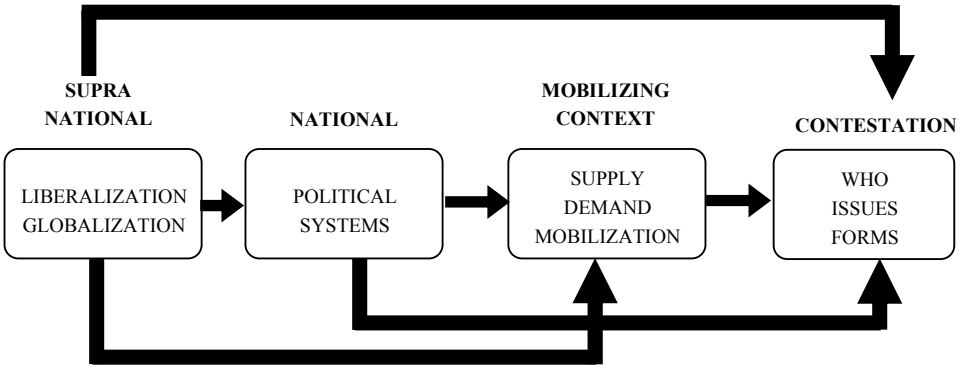
[79] D. McAdam, J.D. McCarthy & M.N. Zald (eds), *Political Opportunities, Mobilizing Structures, and Cultural Framings* (Cambridge University Press, New York, 1996).

[80] Della Porta & Diani, *Social Movements*.

[81] D.A. Snow, S.A. Soule & H. Kriesi (eds), *The Blackwell Companion to Social Movements* (Blackwell Publishing, Oxford, 2004).

against the background of the continent's (contextualized) contestation. Conflict in Africa is still widespread and tenacious and is often rooted in material poverty, scarcity, ecological decline and inequality. Inter-group conflicts are partly related to historical and current international engagements in Africa but also emanate from local tensions and the workings of unequal and corrupt socio-political systems. These international, national and local conflicts translate into and shape daily life and have long-term effects that fuel conflict in new forms. Indeed, if anything, Africa is *the* continent in which to observe contextualized contestation.

Figure 2 Contextualized contestation



Supranational processes. It is increasingly important these days to take the international dimensions of contestation into account and this is certainly true in Africa. First, political and economic liberalization processes have had a profound impact and perhaps even a certain causative influence on the emergence of new social movements or the transformation of existing ones. Second, socio-political changes, shaped by donor-country pressure, global regimes of development policies or ideals and democratization, human-rights discourses and religious expansion appear to have a crucial impact on contestation in Africa. And third, streams of migration have created diasporas in which flows of ideas and resources such as money and organizational experience, but also education, influence the mobilizing structure and thus contentious politics in migrants' home countries. These wider processes of liberalization and globalization (both in terms of influx and outflux) have influenced national political systems, shaped mobilizing structures and had an impact on contentious politics in Africa in ways that remain largely unclear.

In the social movement literature, it is increasingly acknowledged that social movement activity is evolving in response to processes of globalization,[82] and how contention is moving from the national to the transnational level is being examined.[83] Scholars have identified, for instance, the mechanisms and paths along which this scale shift is occurring,[84] the close relationship between global governance institutions, nation states and transnational social movements,[85] and the multilayered opportunity structures in which movements operate nowadays.[86] Briefly, all these studies show that the socio-political context in which movements operate to spread their aims and ideas is not simply national or only supranational but there is a mix of supranational, national and local influences.

National processes. Countries vary in terms of the circumstances they create for contentious politics. The political opportunity structure, the openness of the political system for challengers, the access points available for people to defend their interests and express their opinions and the temporal political configuration have all been identified as determinants of the incidence and type of protest in democratic polities.[87] With regard to Africa, states are often said to be failing, levels of democratization tend to be low and many are being led by corrupt dictators. Apart from pervasive misgovernance and gross abuses of state power, the nature and role of 'ungoverned political spaces' across the continent is poorly understood: how do they enhance conflict and translate it into contentious politics? Although the social movement literature is quite elaborate as far as the effects of repression are concerned, little is yet known about the influence of supranational processes on contention within a state. How do, for instance in Zimbabwe which is arguably one of the world's most repressive states, international lobbies, boycotts, the absence of food and medical care or resources provided by diasporas create chances for social movements to prevent or promote social change? While misgovernance or non-governance, failing states, repression and corruption are not unique to Africa, their direct political impact is probably greater than elsewhere, inhibiting institution-building, development and the fair distribution of resources. Again it remains a question of how the

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82 D. della Porta, H. Kriesi & D. Rucht (eds), *Social Movement in a Globalizing World* (Macmillan, London, 1999); Della Porta & Tarrow, *Transnational Protest and Global Activism*.

83 S. Tarrow & D. McAdam, 'Scale shift in transnational contention', in: Della Porta & Tarrow, *Transnational Protest and Global Activism*.

84 *Ibid*.

85 M. Keck & K. Sikkink, *Activists beyond Borders: Advocacy networks in international politics* (Cornell University Press, Ithaca, NY, 1998).

86 *Ibid*.

87 R. Koopmans, 'Political. Opportunity. Structure. Some splitting to balance the lumping', *Sociological Forum*, 14 (1999), pp. 93-105; Tarrow, *Democracy and Disorder: Protest and politics in Italy*.

sphere of governance, politics, power and the state in specific countries influences the mobilizing context and the quality and extent of contentious politics.

Mobilizing context. The mobilizing context in a country can be described in terms of supply, demand and mobilization.[88] While the demand side of protest refers to the protesters' potential in a society; the supply side refers to the characteristics of the social movement sector in a society. Mobilization refers to the techniques and mechanisms that link supply and demand. We will consider these factors one by one.

A demand for protest begins with levels of grievance in a society.[89] The deep insecurities of life in many African countries – ecological, material, social, political and health-related (notably due to AIDS) – may have a direct impact on perceived grievances and thus on conflict behaviour. New religious identities are also developing in some forms and settings, resulting in radical contentious politics. In addition, it seems plausible that a demand for change is defined by the diasporas as well. How these grievances are shaped by the (supra)national context and translated into demand for protest is an interesting but so far unanswered question. Even less is known about the role of the mobilizing context as translator, facilitator and organizer of ethnic conflict, religious confrontations and resource-related conflicts. Why do certain grievances end up in contentious politics that originate in conflicting principles while others end up in contentious politics originating in conflicting material interests?

With regard to the supply side of contentious politics, this concerns the characteristics of the social movement sector in a society, its strength, diversity and contentiousness. Traditionally, the social movement sector is conceived of as a conglomerate of movement organizations, such as trade unions, associations, liberation movements or civil-society organizations,[90] that provide the more or less formalized infrastructure from which contentious politics is built.[91] Increasingly however, we are seeing protest participation rooted in every-day networks of participants and social movement actors involved in diffuse and decentral-

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88 B. Klandermans, 'The demand and supply of participation: Social-psychological correlates of participation in social movements', in Snow *et al*., *The Blackwell companion to social movements* (Blackwell Publishing, Oxford, 2004).

89 Klandermans, *The Social Psychology of Protest*.

90 McAdam *et al*., *Political Opportunities, Mobilizing Structures, and Cultural Framings*.

91 M. Diani & D. McAdam (eds), *Social Movement Analysis: The network perspective* (Oxford University Press, New York, 2003); D. McAdam, *Freedom Summer* (Oxford University Press, New York, 1988); McCarthy & Zald, 'Resource mobilization and social movements'.

ized networks.[92] How does the political system (repressive or otherwise) shape the supply side? Is it because of repression and/or bans on open mobilization that organizations go underground and turn into loose networks? Egypt and Yemen, where inclusive informal social networks (rather than formal organizations) are an essential mechanism for spreading Islamist ideas,[93] offer examples. Does religious identification influence the political arena in divided countries with a failing political system (e.g. Nigeria) as religious community leaders create alternative routes for mobilization? What do activists and political actors of a previous generation do after their 'projects' have ended in success or failure? Examples here are the evolution of the former leaders and membership of anti-apartheid movements in South Africa and their changing careers. These political actors emanated from social movements and have transformed them.[94] How do social movements and actors evolve in current post-colonial African conditions shaped by liberalization and globalization? How do, for instance, large resourceful organizations, like the UN, with their influential global justice, human rights and democratization framework shape and influence the supply side? Globalization in Africa also entails the rapidly growing role of China (and other Asian countries) on the continent and often evokes counter-responses by Africans.

Finally, processes of mobilization bring demands for protest together with a supply of protest opportunities. Globalization and the development of the network society and the information society have radically changed mobilization techniques. New information and communication technologies have altered the ways in which activists communicate and mobilize. Is typical grassroots mobilization changing as a result of the use of these new communication technologies? How are social actors mobilizing for change in a repressive political system and who is being addressed in a situation of non-governance or misgovernance? How does the spread of innovative ideas and practices, which is playing a central role in the shift of scale,[95] influence the mobilization techniques employed by activists? At a general level, supply, demand and mobilization are supposedly shaped by the supranational and national context. At a certain level, the mobilizing context is further coloured by characteristics of contestation, most notably the specific issue concerned. Little is known about

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92 Duyvendak & Hurenkamp, *Kiezen voor de Kudde. Lichte gemeenschappen en de nieuwe meerderheid*; Melucci, *Challenging Codes*; V. Taylor, 'Mobilizing for change in a social movement society', pp. 219-230.

93 Q. Wiktorowitz, 'Introduction: Islamic activism and social movement theory', in Q. Wiktorowicz (ed.), *Islamic Activism: A social movement approach* (Indiana University Press, Bloomington, IN, 2004).

94 See van Kessel's chapter in this volume.

95 Tarrow & McAdam, 'Scale shift in transnational contention'.

the way mobilizing contexts vary, how such variation is determined or how it impacts on the characteristics of contestation.

In short, we could ask a series of questions concerning contestation with regard to Africa: Who participates in protest? What are their socio-demographic characteristics? Are they the elite or ordinary people? Why are they protesting (i.e. on which issues)? What forms of protest are being employed (i.e. demonstrations, sit-ins, lobbying, riots)? How are they being mobilized?

First, let us look at who the participants are. Some scholars argue that new information and communication technologies are helping to fabricate new connections among people from diverse backgrounds, resulting in mobilizing structures that might be more diverse and inclusive on gender, race and ethnicity, and nationality.[96] Indeed, protest participation has gradually normalized and all sorts of people are resorting to protest to demand change.[97] But it is not clear whether this is the case in Africa too. Are the most deprived people taking to the streets or is it only the elite? Moreover, the question remains as to whether new information and communication technologies are as influential in Africa as they appear to be in the Western world.

The question of *what* people are protesting for focuses on issues and motivation. Issues may have different origins, in the form of conflicting principles or conflicting material interests. For extremely deprived people, the struggle to survive takes up all their time and energy. Does this imply that mainstream African protest has its origin in material interests and that instrumental motivations push people on to the streets?

Concerning forms of protest, the action repertoire is influenced by the (supra)national and mobilizing context. This may have an effect on whether activists organize large mass-based organizations, whether they lobby and organize petitions, or whether discontent turns into bread riots. Obviously, all these forms of contestation have their own motivational dynamics and appeal to different people.

Conclusion

This chapter has discussed how developments in the real world have influenced the study of contention. It started with classical approaches, such as mass society and collective behaviour theories, that tried to explain large movements before the Second World War like Nazism and Communism. The growth of social movement activity with a goal-oriented and rational focus in the 1960s called for more structural and rational approaches such as the political process

[96] Taylor, 'Mobilizing for change in a social movement society'.

[97] Meyer & Tarrow, *Towards a Movement Society?*; see also Norris *et al*., 'Who demonstrates?'

and resource-mobilization approach and for more social constructivistic approaches derived from cultural sociology and social psychology. Since the 1990s, activists mobilizing for social change have been operating in a dramatically changing social-political context. Social movement scholars have reacted with arguments about synergy, making the case for synergizing structural and social constructivistic approaches. The final sections therefore presented an explanatory framework for contextualized contentious politics in which we can integrate influences from supra(national) and mobilizing contexts within a particular country. Obviously, a comprehensive master framework that brings these elements together is still to be built. The most important challenge is probably the integration of the concepts proposed. In this regard, moving from static to more dynamic explanations of contentious politics is important. The recent conceptual shift, proposed by McAdam, Tarrow and Tilly,[98] to look for mechanisms and processes that occur in many different kinds of movements and that lead to different outcomes depending on the specific contexts within which they occur may be a useful direction. Indeed, studying contentious politics in a more dynamic way would do justice to the theoretical and empirical richness of the concepts and could be crucial for gaining better insight into the processes at hand. The study of contentious politics is now much richer, more sophisticated and more synergized than it was sixty years ago. The 'war on paradigms'[99] of the 1980s and 1990s seems to have been replaced by a new decade of 'synergy'.

The 'roadmap' presented here has tried to exemplify the approaches used in the study of social movements over the last sixty years and it is hoped that the explanatory framework will be useful to social movement scholars all over the globe, but especially in Africa. Social movements have been well studied in the European and Latin American contexts but only sporadically in Africa, and then mainly in South Africa. Current developments across African societies might invite social movement scholars to try and explain these dynamics of contention by applying insights from the social movement literature as developed in non-African contexts.

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98 D. McAdam, S. Tarrow & C. Tilly, *Dynamics of Contention* (Cambridge University Press, New York, 2001); McAdam *et al*., 'Comparative perspectives on contentious politics'.

99 S. Tarrow, 'Bridging the quantitative-qualitative divide', in: H.E. Brady & D. Collier (eds), *Rethinking Social Inquiry: Diverse tools, shared standards* (Rowman and Littlefield, Lanham, MD, 2004).